



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 27

# MONTANA

## WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

*Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Montana's family courts and child-welfare system.*

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# 42

MONTANA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 73  
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 36 MONTHS  
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING  
TIME

REPORT GENERATED  
MAY 12, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED  
12 OF 56

COMPILED BY  
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

## 01 NAMED COURT ACTORS · MONTANA

A name appears below only after 3 or more independent families have named the same actor in Montana. Submitter names, emails, and contact details are never published. Comments below are direct family reports — one per family — with all identifying information removed.

## Camisha Sawtelle

GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · CHILD ATTORNEY · 3 FAMILIES

"She represents a lot of kids in this county. She is not a family lawyer, she is an environmental lawyer. She never stands up for the children. Unless family comes forward and wants the kids, she seems to rally for certain foster parents to keep kids, over family. We have reached out to her over all the abuse allegations, she won't even respond." **FLATHEAD COUNTY**

"She does not stand up for or advocate for the children. The first week the kids were back with their parents, they were choked. She didn't see anything wrong with it"

"She defames my character all the time. She fought tooth and nail for my children to not go with our aunt, who is already a licensed foster home"

## Dev Haegele

CPS WORKER · FLATHEAD · 3 FAMILIES

"She came on the case and the 1st visit she was terrible to us. Then said she was returning the kids to the abusive parents. We are the aunt and uncle to the birth mother."

"CPS worker. She is allowing the kids to stay in an abusive environment. Treats the kinship foster parents extremely bad"  
**FLATHEAD COUNTY**

"She lies and put children in harms way all the time"

## Hon. Amy Poehling Eddy

JUDGE · FLATHEAD COUNTY · 3 FAMILIES

"Conflict of interest falsifying information unlawfully ripping kids out of my life ignoring domestic violence ignoring my kids witnessing the abuse abusing her color of law allowing my kids to get beaten and molested because I wasn't able to be there and protect them. As well as her being involved in criminal charges in past trying to shut me up before"

"Confidential information handed to other side, discovery allowed in a third party guardianship (that is NOT SUPPOSED TO HAPPEN!) awarded attorney fees, FOR WHAT?! Said "taken as truth" because why?!?! Struck my record of evidence?! What!!!!!! Went past six month mark?! Perjury obviously committed by other side!!!!!! Allowed to happen?!?!?!" **FLATHEAD COUNTY**

## Jodi Christiansen

CPS WORKER · FLATHEAD · 3 FAMILIES

"Ahe is the cps supervisor. She neglects to supervise. She lets all the workers under her play God and just goes along with it."

"Cps supervisor. Lets all the workers under her go rogue and do what they want. Will not return calls."

"She is the CPS supervisor she allows the people under her to go rogue and do whatever they want." **FLATHEAD COUNTY**

**Public threshold rule:** Names are grouped conservatively by normalized spelling, role, and location. Common titles, punctuation, casing, and middle initials collapse together. Close misspellings are not auto-merged without admin review. Only family-direct submissions count toward the public threshold.

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

# MONTANA AT A GLANCE.

Across 42 Montana families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

|                                                                                               |                                                                                                                   |                                                                          |                                                                                     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div>CHILDREN IMPACTED</div> <div>73</div> <div>42 of 42 families reported child counts</div> | <div>MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN</div> <div>\$156,000</div> <div>median across 21 families reporting 3+ categories</div> | <div>MEDIAN MONTHS LOST</div> <div>36</div> <div>of parenting time</div> | <div>WENT PRO SE</div> <div>59.5%</div> <div>47.6% after running out of money</div> |
| <div>SUBMISSIONS</div> <div>42</div>                                                          | <div>AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY</div> <div>1.7</div>                                                                   | <div>FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN</div> <div>42 of 42</div>               | <div>COUNTIES REPRESENTED</div> <div>12</div>                                       |

## WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Montana families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

03

THE COST OF MONTANA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

| EXPENSE CATEGORY                                           | RESPONSES | MEDIAN    | MEAN     | TOTAL REPORTED |
|------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|-----------|----------|----------------|
| Attorney Fees                                              | 32        | \$13,500  | \$35,834 | \$1,146,700    |
| Lost Wages                                                 | 25        | \$15,000  | \$49,596 | \$1,239,890    |
| Other Court Fees                                           | 18        | \$625     | \$2,486  | \$44,750       |
| Therapy / Evaluations                                      | 21        | \$1,500   | \$4,608  | \$96,759       |
| Reunification Services                                     | 13        | \$0       | \$1,546  | \$20,100       |
| GAL Fees                                                   | 16        | \$0       | \$1,456  | \$23,300       |
| Asset Loss <sup>1</sup>                                    | 21        | \$8,000   | —        | —              |
| Median Family Burden (21 families reporting 3+ categories) | —         | \$156,000 | —        | —              |

**Median vs. mean:** Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

**1. On asset loss:** One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$8,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

|                           |                        |       |           |
|---------------------------|------------------------|-------|-----------|
| Median months lost        | <div><div></div></div> | 36    | 3 yrs     |
| Mean months lost          | <div><div></div></div> | 52    | 4.3 yrs   |
| Total across all families | <div><div></div></div> | 1,456 | 121.3 yrs |

## 04 WHO IS REPORTING · MONTANA

Most families documenting in Montana are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

## CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

## CASE STATUS

|                                    |  |    |     |
|------------------------------------|--|----|-----|
| Active case: stuck or delayed      |  | 21 | 50% |
| Not provided                       |  | 7  | 17% |
| Case closed: more than 2 years ago |  | 6  | 14% |
| Active case: progress being made   |  | 3  | 7%  |
| Case closed: within last 2 years   |  | 3  | 7%  |

## SYSTEM AFFECTED

|                                      |  |    |     |
|--------------------------------------|--|----|-----|
| Both Family Court and CPS            |  | 18 | 43% |
| Family Court Only                    |  | 18 | 43% |
| CPS (Child Protective Services) Only |  | 3  | 7%  |
| Unknown                              |  | 3  | 7%  |

## DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

## TIME IN SYSTEM

|                   |  |    |     |
|-------------------|--|----|-----|
| 5 – 10 years      |  | 12 | 29% |
| 1 – 3 years       |  | 12 | 29% |
| 3 – 5 years       |  | 7  | 17% |
| Over 10 years     |  | 7  | 17% |
| 6 months – 1 year |  | 1  | 2%  |

## CUSTODY STATUS

|                                   |  |    |     |
|-----------------------------------|--|----|-----|
| No Contact / Total Loss of Access |  | 17 | 40% |
| 50/50 Joint                       |  | 13 | 31% |
| Visitation Only                   |  | 6  | 14% |
| Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)   |  | 3  | 7%  |
| Full Custody                      |  | 2  | 5%  |

## GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

## TOP COUNTIES

|                 |  |    |     |
|-----------------|--|----|-----|
| Yellowstone     |  | 11 | 26% |
| Flathead        |  | 9  | 21% |
| Cascade         |  | 4  | 10% |
| Gallatin        |  | 2  | 5%  |
| Lewis And Clark |  | 2  | 5%  |
| Park            |  | 2  | 5%  |

## TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

|                                                                             |  |    |     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|----|-----|
| False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report) |  | 11 | 26% |
| Other: (Short answer)                                                       |  | 7  | 17% |
| High Conflict Divorce                                                       |  | 6  | 14% |
| Other                                                                       |  | 5  | 12% |
| Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)         |  | 4  | 10% |

**05 PARENT VOICES — MONTANA**

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Montana comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



*Hurt me and my children destroyed their lives and mine makes them live their abuser who made my son autistic*

— BOBBIE

**ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS**

Due process in family court is a fiction. Our courts are violating the Constitution of the United States and they are shielding those judgements from constitutional scrutiny by invoking state specific statutes and rules to explain their actions. Parental rights have truly been [...]

— MONTANA PARENT · CIARA

**MORE VOICES FROM MONTANA**

Having to navigate a system where corrupt attorneys who play some sick game with your kids lives and to try and force a protective mother to bend to the will of a dangerous pedophile; a GAL hiding behind a psychologist degree who mocks and insults you and refused to follow the [...]

— MARIAH

Made me lose everything traumatized abused and neglected

— LINDSEY

By endorsing factually impossible recommendations and ignoring documented non-compliance, the current legal process has systematically deprived my children of stability and safety while allowing their developmental milestones to be traded for high-conflict trauma.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Yellowstone cps and family lass multiplied my abusers power ten fold. It's business as usual.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

## 05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



*Tore apart my family. Traumatized my kids and lead them to believe I had abandoned them.*

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court has absolutely ruined my kids, their relationship with their step dad, who mind you pays all the bills and would hang the moon for them. It has never once made a motion in the best interest of the children, it has all been money moved!

— CALLIE

Our nephews and niece have been removed from our care, and placed back into an extremely abusive home. Lots of new allegations of abuse.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

We are in constant worry mode for the safety of the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Jodi should be fired for all she has done to children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It destroyed me ruined my quality of life . The constant targeting has made me feel unsafe . And in constant worry for my children's safety. I miss my children so much. It's caused intense grief because of the intense powerlessness. I almost went to prison and I was all over the [...]

— TAMBI

Make us grieve for one another

— MANDY

Sucked into a system that never had the best interest of my children and. Left with lost time never to get back.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my family. We went in with trust and came out with lost hope and dreams

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

## 05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



*The system has broken apart my family. But hasn't broken me. I will continue to fight!*

— SARA

It has utterly destroyed us. I left town and disappeared but I'm building my girls a homestead for their 18th birthday. They were 1 and 3 when they were stolen.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

For a year the children have been in reunification counseling with their dad. He has sat by while she decided to separate them, threaten them, deny the abuse (proven) he had towards them and tell them I am a bad mother even though he went to rehab and gave me full custody after [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Josh Van de Wetering , Adrienne Ellington and Brian Acheson , supported false allegations in the family, civil, state and federal courtrooms until they were exposed for supporting perjury to harass families while benefiting to perpetuate harassment.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The systems allowing the violations of federal laws/icwa, my parental rights, ect but mostly caused mental harm to my family and self, my daughter's injuries in state care have caused trauma and anxiety in my daughter. Iv still never received any documents about my daughter's [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system falsely said that I was inappropriate with my daughter and denied my wife and I essential medical care. They used my father's false diagnosis of Alzheimer's to pin me for a mental illness because my ex wife was a nurse. They then took Alzheimer's off my father's [...]

— BRYAN

Instead of working together, lawyers and the family court has taken best friends and made us enemies. And the only one getting hurt is our daughter.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

## 05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



*Mother has 74 failed mental health evaluations. I passed my one court ordered mental health evaluation, and my daughter was ripped from my arms.. when I had full custody mother was granted every weekend with her having full custody. I get the first and third weekend for [...]*

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Divide to conquer. Their overreach has to be stopped. They want to break the strongest bond in the world, between a mom and her kids. Its unconstitutional. It's sick.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has left one child disabled due to purjury and medical neglect and permanent memory loss; along with my other two children also experiencing medical and physical neglect.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

As torn me and my family apart has put a ton of pressure on my mom they've taken advantage of my Mom they're taking away my rights as a mother and I barely even get the time to call or talk to my daughter they have made every excuse in the book to keep me away from my daughter [...]

— KAYLE

The system stole time that can't be given back deprived of making memories that should of been remembered in stories later told that would help you feel sense of belonging, rooted with sense of family unity. Instead of feelings of loneliness worthlessness abandonment, looking [...]

— HEATHER

They have bypassed every guideline put into place to prevent third party take over. What they did was a\*\*backwards. Amy Eddy. Failed our children. And she preaches she loves our constitution. Really?? Certainly not the part about parents and their children. And Marybeth Sampsel [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Effectively torn my daughters from 4 generations of living families in mine and my ex husband's maternal side. .for political power and cult like control... Even school in Bigfork... Therapists .. I call those two .. theRAPISTS.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

29 Montana parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 29 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

**06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — MONTANA**

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Montana families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

Hurt me and my children destroyed their lives and mine makes them live their abuser who made my son autistic

— BOBBIE

Having to navigate a system where corrupt attorneys who play some sick game with your kids lives and to try and force a protective mother to bend to the will of a dangerous pedophile; a GAL hiding behind a psychologist degree who mocks and insults you and refused to follow the law of GAL investigating for the best interests of the children has been utter, bullshit! It should be obvious that a dangerous pedophile should not have any contact with children whether biological or not, and that these sicko attorneys arent following the law board rules

— MARIAH

Made me lose everything traumatized abused and neglected

— LINDSEY

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**06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED**

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— TAMBI

Make us grieve for one another

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

**06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED**

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

**06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED**

The system falsely said that I was inappropriate with my daughter and denied my wife and I essential medical care. They used my father's false diagnosis of Alzheimer's to pin me for a mental illness because my ex wife was a nurse. They then took Alzheimer's off my father's record and said he had Parkinson's due to his agent orange exposure. They mixed up my father and my medical records in the medical system and tried killing my current wife because she saw through the slander. They were prepared to let me die as well with a tumor in my spinal cord and hid it behind the false allegations of racism and discrimination. I am biracial as well with African American, Native American and Caucasian blood. I have been labeled as homophobic and other stuff as well while I was active duty in the USAF.

— BRYAN

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**06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED**

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— KAYLE

The system stole time that can't be given back deprived of making memories that should of been remembered in stories later told that would help you feel sense of belonging, rooted with sense of family unity. Instead of feelings of loneliness worthlessness abandonment, looking for brief comfort in drugs ECT after being deprived ability to give and receive love to rebuild strengthen parent/child relationships,

— HEATHER

They have bypassed every guideline put into place to prevent third party take over. What they did was a\*\*backwards. Amy Eddy. Failed our children. And she preaches she loves our constitution. Really?? Certainly not the part about parents and their children. And Marybeth Sampsel Advocate for families?! That is a really cute way of saying predator.

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29 full approved Montana comments are included in this appendix.

## 07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

### WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Montana report comes from Montana respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Montana — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

### WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 42 Montana families reporting here are not the universe of Montana families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

### METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through [standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey](https://standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey). Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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### ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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